EMPOWR REPORT · 2025

A Non-Medical Approach to Mental Health

The UK is facing a mental health crisis that medication and therapy alone cannot solve. This report makes the case for experiential learning — a proven, cost-effective approach to building resilience and promoting lifelong wellbeing for people of all ages.

1 in 4
adults experience a mental health problem each year

8.7M
antidepressant prescriptions in England in 2023/24

+45%
rise in NHS mental health contacts since 2019

11.4
per 100,000 — suicide rate in 2023, highest since 1999

Sources: NHS Digital, ONS — see references below.

THE PROBLEM

When Medical Alone Isn't Enough

While medical treatments are essential for many, the data tells a troubling story. There is a widening gap between demand and supply in NHS services — with long wait times and rising disability claims for mental ill-health. Antidepressant use has more than doubled since 2015, yet the prevalence of common mental health disorders continues to climb year on year.

Among young people, probable mental disorder prevalence nearly doubled between 2017 and 2023 — from 12.5% to 20.3% for 8–16 year olds, and from 10.1% to 23.3% for 17–19 year olds. These trends highlight an urgent need for complementary, non-medical strategies.

THE SCIENCE

Why Experiential Learning Works

Experiential learning is a structured cycle in which individuals *do* (engage in purposeful, often novel activity), *reflect* (analyse the experience), *conceptualise* (draw general principles) and *apply* (transfer insights to new situations).

Science shows that the brain, like the body, thrives on stimulation. Just as physical exercise strengthens muscles, engaging in challenging experiences triggers **neuroplasticity**— forming new neural connections, boosting cognitive flexibility, and promoting emotional resilience. Without such mental exercise, neural pathways weaken, reducing our ability to adapt to and navigate life's complexities.

Through carefully designed experiential learning programmes, Empowr introduces individuals to fresh challenges that stimulate brain activity at a cellular level. This activation leads to the creation of new neural pathways, improving brain function, reducing stress hormones, and enhancing the body's natural ability to stay adaptable.

Without regular and meaningful stimulation, our neural connections weaken, and our ability to grow, cope, and thrive diminishes. That's why we create hands-on experiences that keep people thinking, moving, and connecting — nurturing sharper minds, stronger bodies, and deeper human connection.

THE EVIDENCE

What the Research Shows

🧠

Neuroplasticity

Repeated engagement in novel, hands-on activities leads to growth of new neural pathways and improved brain health.

💪

Resilience & Self-Efficacy

Real-world challenges foster confidence, adaptability, and coping strategies — skills protective against anxiety and depression.

🤝

Social Connection

Group-based experiential learning directly counteracts isolation — a recognised driver of poor mental health.

🌿

Physical Health Synergy

Movement-rich and outdoor-based programmes deliver simultaneous mental and physical benefits, reducing stress hormones and enhancing emotional regulation.

📈

Long-Term Impact

Participatory, experiential learning models in schools, communities, and workplaces improve mood, lower anxiety, and reduce healthcare reliance.

THE ECONOMIC CASE

A Smarter Investment in Society

Humans — regardless of age — are wired to seek progress and thrive on accomplishment. Whether mastering a new skill, moving with more confidence, or simply showing up and trying again, these experiences have a measurable effect on brain health and emotional stability. As more people feel capable and fulfilled, their contribution to society naturally increases.

💼

Greater Workforce Engagement

Individuals who stay mentally and physically active are more focused, adaptable, and productive — better able to maintain a healthy work-life balance.

🏥

Health System Relief

Improving mental resilience reduces reliance on NHS services — freeing resources for critical, acute care.

🌍

A More Resilient Population

A society built on continual learning and personal agency is more resilient in the face of social, economic, and technological change.

🔄

Indirect Public Benefit

The psychological effects of learning and achievement — increased dopamine and serotonin — naturally lead to more positive social behaviour and community contribution.

OUR COMMITMENT

Leading the Movement

The statistics are clear: the UK is facing a mental health crisis that cannot be solved by medication and therapy alone. Experiential learning is a powerful yet under-utilised tool — scientifically proven to build resilience, foster connection, and promote lifelong wellbeing. Integrating it into communities, schools, and health systems offers tangible progress for the millions who are struggling.

Empowr is committed to leading this movement — because we believe in the potential for every individual to thrive through experience.

Sources & References

1. Milicevic, A., Milton, I. & O'Loughlin, C. (2016). Experiential reflective learning as a foundation for emotional resilience. *International Journal of Educational Research, 80*, 25–36.
2. Coventry, P. A. et al. (2021). Nature-based outdoor activities for mental and physical health: A systematic review and meta-analysis. *SSM — Population Health, 16*, 100934.
3. Gummelt, G. et al. (2024). Experiential learning in mental health diversion: Interdisciplinary approaches using Kolb's learning theory. *Journal of Evidence-Based Social Work, 22*(2), 171–188.
4. Reece, J. (2025). Evaluating the effectiveness of adventure therapy in anxiety-related disorders. *Journal of Counselling and Development, 103*(3), 321–340.
5. Grassini, S. (2022). A systematic review and meta-analysis of nature walk as an intervention for anxiety and depression. *Journal of Clinical Medicine, 11*(6), 1731.
6. NHS Business Services Authority (2024). *Mental Health Medicines Statistics 2023/24: Antidepressant Prescribing.*
7. NHS Digital (2023). *Mental Health of Children and Young People in England, 2023 — Wave 4 Follow-up.*
8. NHS England (2025). *Mental Health Services Monthly Statistics — November 2024 (Final).*
9. NHS England (2019). *Mental Health Services Monthly Statistics — March 2019 (Final).*
10. NHS England (2016). *Mental Health Services Monthly Statistics — November 2016 (Final).*
11. Office for National Statistics (2024). *Suicides in England and Wales: 2023 Registrations.*
12. King's Fund (2025). *Mental Health 360°: Service and Workforce Trends.*
13. The Sunday Times (2025, 15 June). Antidepressant use doubles among teenagers.